Crash Course · Complete Beginner's Guide

Business Workflows, ERP Systems & Odoo

A Complete Beginner's Guide — From Zero to Operational

01 · Business Workflows

02 · ERP Systems

03 · Odoo Platform

What You Will Learn Today

01 Business Workflows

What is a workflow? → Why they matter → Types → Real examples

02 ERP Systems

What is ERP? → Core modules → Before vs after → Unifying data

03 Odoo Platform

What is Odoo? → Key apps → Navigation → Demo walkthrough

SECTION 01

Business Workflows

01

Understanding how work actually gets done

- What is a workflow?
- Why workflows matter
- Sequential vs Parallel
- Real-world example
- Mapping a workflow
- Automation opportunities

What Is a Business Workflow?

Simple Definition

A workflow is a structured sequence of steps that transforms an input (a request, raw material, or data) into a defined output — a product, decision, or completed task.

Everyday Analogy — Ordering Coffee

Customer orders	→	Cashier records
Barista prepares	→	Cashier calls name
Customer collects		✓ Done

3 Core Elements

- Trigger — What starts the process
- Steps — Tasks by people or systems
- Outcome — End result + hand-off

Why Every Business Has Workflows

- **Consistency:** Same process every time — regardless of who does it
- **Accountability:** Every step has a named owner — no ambiguity
- **Measurability:** Track time, cost, and quality at each step
- **Improvability:** Can't improve what isn't documented
- **Automation:** Systems can only automate defined processes

Even informal processes are workflows — writing them down makes them improvable.

Why Workflows Matter — The Cost of Chaos

Without Documented Workflows

- Inconsistency — two employees handle the same task differently
- Bottlenecks — work piles up waiting for one approver
- Lost information — decisions made verbally, no audit trail
- Long onboarding — new hires have no guide to follow
- Errors — skipped steps, wrong versions, missing signatures

With Documented Workflows

- Every team member follows the same proven process
- Managers can pinpoint exactly where delays occur
- Full audit trail — every step is logged and searchable
- New hires onboard in days, not weeks
- Repetitive steps are automated — freeing people for higher-value work

Types of Business Workflows

Sequential Workflows

Steps happen in strict order. Step 2 cannot start until Step 1 is complete.

Example — Purchase Order:

1. Department requests item
2. Manager approves
3. Finance checks budget
4. Procurement places order
5. Warehouse receives goods
6. Invoice paid

Parallel Workflows

Multiple steps happen simultaneously to save time.

Example — Employee Onboarding:

At the same time:

- → IT sets up laptop & email
- → HR prepares contract
- → Manager schedules intro meetings
- → Finance sets up payroll

All paths merge when employee starts Day 1

Deep Dive Example: Sales Order Workflow

Real-World Scenario: A customer calls to order 50 units of Product X. What happens inside the business?

1

Sales Team

Creates a Sales Quotation → checks current stock availability → sends price quote to customer → customer approves

2

Inventory / Warehouse

Confirms 50 units in stock → reserves them → prepares picking list for the warehouse team

3

Delivery

Items picked, packed, and shipped → delivery note generated → customer receives goods and signs

4

Finance

Invoice auto-generated from confirmed order → sent to customer → payment received → ledger updated

How to Map a Workflow — 5 Steps

1 Identify the Trigger

What event starts this process? Customer request, employee action, or scheduled time.

2 List Every Step

Interview people who actually do the work. Observe. Don't rely only on manager descriptions.

3 Assign Ownership

Every step needs one responsible person or role — not 'the team.'

4 Identify Inputs & Outputs

What data or document enters each step?

Tools for Mapping

Flowcharts (Lucidchart, Draw.io), swimlane diagrams, or BPMN notation. Start simple — even a whiteboard works.

5 Find Bottlenecks

Where does work wait? Who must approve? These are prime targets for automation.

SECTION 02

ERP Systems

02

The software backbone of a modern business

- What is ERP?
- Before vs after ERP
- Core ERP modules
- End-to-end integration
- Choosing an ERP
- Total Cost of Ownership

What Is an ERP System?

ERP = Enterprise Resource Planning

A single software platform that integrates all core business functions — accounting, inventory, sales, HR, purchasing — into one shared database. Every department works with the same live data, eliminating duplicate entry and information silos.

Before ERP — The Island Problem

- Sales uses spreadsheets, Accounting uses different software, Warehouse uses paper records
- Each team has their own version of 'truth' — data is duplicated and contradicts itself

After ERP — One Source of Truth

- Every department works in the same system with real-time data
- A sales order auto-updates inventory, triggers invoicing, posts to the ledger

ERP Modules Overview



ERP doesn't replace your workflows — it digitizes and automates them.

Core ERP Modules — What Each One Does

Accounting & Finance

→ Invoices, payments, ledger

→ Tax reports, bank reconciliation

→ Real-time financial dashboards

Inventory & Warehouse

→ Stock tracking & movements

→ Purchase orders & deliveries

→ Warehousing & bin management

Sales & CRM

→ Leads, quotations, orders

→ Follow-ups & opportunity pipeline

→ Customer history & analytics

Purchasing

→ Supplier management & RFQs

→ Purchase orders & receipts

→ 3-way matching: PO → Receipt → Bill

Human Resources

→ Employee records & contracts

→ Attendance, payroll, leave

→ Recruitment & appraisals

Manufacturing

→ Bills of materials (BoM)

→ Work orders & production runs

→ Capacity planning & scheduling

Life Before ERP vs After ERP

Without ERP

- Month-end close takes 2 weeks — data collected manually from every department
- Inventory count is always wrong — sales and warehouse have different numbers
- Customer calls asking for order status — sales rep must email warehouse and wait
- A single invoice requires 4 emails and two spreadsheets to produce
- Management reports are always 2 weeks out of date

With ERP

- Month-end closes in 2 days — all transactions already in the system
- Inventory is live and accurate — every pick, receive, and transfer updates instantly
- Sales rep sees order status in 10 seconds without contacting anyone
- Invoice auto-generated from the confirmed sales order — one click
- CEO has a live dashboard updated every minute

How ERP Connects Departments — End-to-End Flow

Scenario: A customer places an order. Watch how ERP automatically connects every department.

Sales Confirms Order	Warehouse Picks Goods	Goods Dispatched	Invoice Sent, Paid
Inventory module reserves stock immediately. Customer credit limit checked automatically.	Warehouse module shows pick list. Staff scans barcodes. Stock decrements in real time.	Delivery confirmation triggers automatic invoice creation in the Accounting module.	Payment auto-reconciled with bank statement. Revenue posted to correct ledger account.

At every step: zero manual re-entry · Zero email chains · One system · All data linked.

How to Choose an ERP — Key Questions

1 Business size & growth plan?

Small/medium → cloud ERP (Odoo, NetSuite).
Large enterprises → SAP, Oracle , Odoo.

2 Which modules do you need?

Start with Accounting + Inventory + Sales. Add HR, Manufacturing later.

3 Cloud or on-premise?

Cloud = lower upfront cost, auto-updates, anywhere access.
On-premise = more control, higher IT cost.

4 Total Cost of Ownership?

License + customization + implementation + training + maintenance

Key Insight

The most expensive ERP is rarely the best fit. Match the tool to the actual business need, team size, and budget — not to what competitors are using.

SECTION 03

Odoo Platform

03

Open-source ERP built for every business size

- What is Odoo?
- Key application modules
- Interface navigation
- Full sales workflow
- Odoo vs other tools
- Getting started

What Is Odoo?

Odoo at a Glance

Open-source, modular ERP platform covering everything from CRM to accounting to e-commerce — install only the modules you need.

- **Founded:** 2005, Belgium — now 12M+ users in 100+ countries
- **Modules:** 80+ official apps — CRM, Sales, Inventory, Accounting, HR, Manufacturing
- **Editions:** Community (free & open-source) + Enterprise (advanced features + support)
- **Deployment:** Cloud SaaS (Odoo Online) or self-hosted on your own servers

Why popular for SMEs: cheaper than SAP/Oracle · modern UI · one platform · one subscription

Odoo Replaces All of These

CRM & Sales	→ Salesforce, HubSpot CRM
Accounting	→ QuickBooks, Xero, Zoho Books
Inventory	→ Fishbowl, inFlow
HR & Payroll	→ BambooHR, Gusto
E-commerce	→ Shopify, WordPress + WooCommerce

5 separate SaaS tools at $50/user = $250/user/month.
Odoo Enterprise: ~$31/user/month all-in.

Odoo's Most-Used Apps

CRM

Manage leads & pipeline

Sales

Quotes & orders

Invoicing

Billing & payments

Inventory

Stock & warehouses

Purchase

Supplier orders

Accounting

Full double-entry

HR

Employees & payroll

Project

Tasks & timesheets

Website

Online store & CMS

Navigating the Odoo Interface

1 The Main Menu (App Switcher)

Click the grid icon (top-left) to see all installed apps. Each app opens its own workspace — like switching between different departments.

2 Inside Each App — 3 Views

List View — all records in a table, good for bulk actions.
Kanban View — cards in columns, great for CRM or project tasks.
Form View — the detail view of one record; where you edit, approve, or create.

3 Key Interface Elements

Search bar — powerful filters, group-by, and saved favorites.
Breadcrumbs — always shows where you are; click to go back.
Action buttons — 'New', 'Save', 'Confirm' are context-sensitive.
Chatter — the log at the bottom of every record; all emails, notes, and changes.

Odoo in Action — Full Sales Workflow

Scenario: A new customer enquires about a product. Follow the complete Odoo journey from lead to paid invoice.

CRM App	Sales App	Inventory App	Invoicing / Accounting
Capture the Lead	**Create a Quotation**	**Process Delivery**	**Get Paid**
Create a new Opportunity. Log customer details and requirements. Move to 'Qualified' stage on the Kanban board.	Convert opportunity to Quotation. Add product lines, quantities, prices. Send to customer directly via Odoo email. Customer confirms.	Odoo auto-creates a Delivery Order. Warehouse team validates the pick. Stock levels update instantly. Delivery confirmed.	Click 'Create Invoice' — all lines auto-populate. Send invoice. Register payment when received. Revenue posts to ledger automatically.

How to Get Started with Odoo — Practical Steps

1 Try the free demo

Go to odoo.com → 'Try it free'. 15-day full-featured trial — no credit card required.

2 Identify your core 3 modules

Don't install everything. Start with your biggest pain points — usually Sales, Inventory, and Invoicing.

3 Set up your master data first

Products, customers, suppliers, chart of accounts. Get this clean before going live.

4 Run a pilot with one team

Don't flip the whole company on day one. Pick

Free Learning Library

Odoo has a vast free learning library at odoo.com/slides — organized by module and role. Certificates available for each track.

5 Train by doing, not watching

Use Odoo eLearning (odoo.com/slides) and process real test transactions — learning only

ERP Systems Compared — Odoo vs SAP vs Oracle vs Local ERP

	Odoo	SAP	Oracle NetSuite	Local ERP
Best For	SMEs & mid-market (1–500 staff)	Large enterprises & multinationals	Mid-large companies, cloud-first	Very small businesses, single-country
Pricing	~$25–45/user/mo · Free Community	$150–300+/user/mo + huge impl. cost	$99–299+/user/month	$500–5K one-time license
Implementation Time	2–6 months	12–36 months	6–18 months	1–3 months (limited scope)
No. of Modules	80+ apps (CRM, Mfg, HR, Web…)	100+ (Finance, SCM, HR, Analytics…)	Financials, SCM, HCM, EPM, CX	Basic: Finance, HR, Inventory only
Ease of Use	Modern intuitive UI	Complex, needs specialists	Functional, dated UI	Simple, limited
Customisation	High — open-source, large community	Very high — expensive ABAP devs	Moderate — partner ecosystem	Low — vendor-dependent, slow
Cloud / SaaS	Fully cloud or self-hosted	SAP Rise cloud or on-premise	Cloud-native (Oracle Cloud)	⚠ Usually on-premise only
MENA / Egypt Support	Many certified partners	⚠ Few partners, high cost	⚠ Limited, large-firm focus	Local vendor, Arabic UI, VAT

When to Choose Which ERP — Decision Guide

Odoo

RECOMMENDED FOR SMEs

IDEAL FOR

- Growing businesses 5–500 staff
- Multi-department integration needed
- Budget-conscious organisations
- Fast go-live required (2–6 months)
- E-commerce + ERP in one platform

⚠ THINK TWICE IF

- Very large multinationals (1000+ users)
- Extremely complex multi-GAAP reporting

~$25–45 / user / month

★★★★★ 9/10 for SMEs

SAP S/4HANA

FOR LARGE ENTERPRISES

IDEAL FOR

- Large multinationals 500+ employees
- Complex global supply chains
- Heavy financial compliance reporting
- Dedicated SAP IT team available
- Industries: Mfg, Oil & Gas, Pharma

⚠ THINK TWICE IF

- SMEs — overkill & extremely costly
- Teams needing quick deployment

$150–300+ / user / month + impl.

★★☆☆☆ 4/10 for SMEs

Oracle NetSuite

FOR CLOUD-FIRST MID-MARKET

IDEAL FOR

- Mid-market companies 50–1000 staff
- Fast-growing, multi-subsidiary firms
- Multi-currency & multi-country ops
- Professional services & SaaS cos.
- US / UK market primary focus

⚠ THINK TWICE IF

- Very small businesses (too complex)
- Companies needing strong Arabic support

$99–299+ / user / month

★★★☆☆ 6/10 for SMEs

Local ERP

BASIC LOCAL COMPLIANCE

IDEAL FOR

- Very small businesses 1–20 staff
- Single-country, simple operations
- Arabic UI & local VAT compliance
- Minimal IT budget or resources

⚠ THINK TWICE IF

- Companies planning to grow & expand
- Need CRM, e-commerce, or manufacturing

$500–5,000 one-time license

★★☆☆☆ 4/10 long-term

For most Egyptian and MENA businesses: Odoo delivers 90% of SAP's capabilities at 10% of the cost — with local certified partners available.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

01 Business workflows are the backbone of every organization — mapping them reveals inefficiencies and enables automation.

02 ERP systems unify all departments into one database, eliminating duplicate data, manual hand-offs, and information silos.

03 Odoo is a modern, affordable ERP that can replace 5–10 separate software tools with one integrated platform.





Thank You